IELTS Listening Practice Test

Transcript — Parts 1–4 · Episode 3

PART 1

You will hear a man called Arthur booking a photography workshop with a receptionist called Beatrice. You now have some time to look at questions 1 to 10.

Speaker B: Good morning, City Photography Workshops. Beatrice speaking. How can I help you today?

Speaker A: Hello, I'd like to book a place on one of your weekend workshops, please. I saw it advertised online.

Speaker B: Certainly! Let me get our booking form up on my screen. First, can I take your name?

Speaker A: Yes, it's Arthur Pemberton.

Speaker B: Could you spell your last name for me, please?

Speaker A: Of course. It's P-E-M-B-E-R-T-O-N.

Speaker B: Great, thank you. And do you have a contact number?

Speaker A: Yes, my mobile is 0-7-7-0-0-9-0-0-1-4-2.

Speaker B: Let me just write that down... 0-7-7-0-0-9-0-0-1-4-2. Got it. Now, which workshop were you interested in?

Speaker A: I was looking at the Close-up and Nature Photography session on the 14th of October.

Speaker B: Excellent choice. That's a Saturday. Oh, actually, let me check... yes, we still have three slots left for the 14th of October. We also have one on the 28th, but that's focusing on urban landscapes.

Speaker A: No, the 14th of October is definitely the one for me.

Speaker B: Perfect. And what level of experience would you say you have? We offer Beginner, Intermediate, and Advanced options.

Speaker A: I've been shooting for a couple of years, so I think I'm past the basic stage. I'd like to sign up for the intermediate level, please.

Speaker B: Wonderful. For that particular workshop, we recommend bringing a macro lens if you have one. Do you have your own, or would you need to hire one from us?

Speaker A: I actually bought a macro lens last month, so I'll bring my own.

Speaker B: That's great. It saves you the hire fee! Now, just so you know, the group is meeting at the entrance of the public library, rather than our main office. It's right next to the park where the practical session takes place.

Speaker A: Oh, the library on Queen Street?

Speaker B: Yes, that's the one. There's plenty of parking nearby. Now, regarding payment, how would you like to pay? We accept credit cards, bank transfers, or PayPal.

Speaker A: PayPal would be the easiest for me, if that's alright.

Speaker B: That's fine. We'll send a payment link to your email. The total fee for the intermediate workshop is eighty-five pounds.

Speaker A: Eighty-five pounds, okay. I have a membership card for the local arts society. Does that give me a discount?

Speaker B: Yes, it does! It gives you a ten percent discount. I just need your membership card number to apply it.

Speaker A: Sure, let me get it out. The number is 8-4-2-9-1-5.

Speaker B: Let me just repeat that back: 8-4-2-9-1-5.

Speaker A: That's correct.

Speaker B: Great, that brings the price down. Lastly, just for our records, how did you first hear about our workshops? Was it through our social media page?

Speaker A: Actually, I first saw it in your monthly newsletter. My friend forwarded it to me because he knew I wanted to improve my skills.

Speaker B: Ah, the newsletter! That's good to know. Well, that's all booked for you, Arthur. You'll receive a confirmation email shortly.

Speaker A: Thank you very much for your help, Beatrice.

Speaker B: You're very welcome. Have a great day!

This is the end of Part 1.

PART 2

You will hear a local community organizer called Clara giving a talk about a new community garden. You now have some time to look at questions 11 to 20.

Speaker B: Hello everyone, thank you for coming to tonight's meeting of the Oak Tree Community Garden Project. I'm Clara, and I'm delighted to share some exciting updates about our brand-new green space. It's been a long journey, but we've finally secured the land. It's the old railway yard behind the train station. Many of you had suggested the plot behind the supermarket or the lawn next to the council offices, but the railway yard was ultimately selected because it has the best soil quality and gets the most sunlight throughout the day.

Now, I want to talk about how the garden will be structured. We've decided to divide the space into two main zones. The eastern section will be dedicated entirely to growing fruit and vegetables. This will be a communal effort, and the harvest will be shared among all active volunteers. The western section will feature raised beds for herbs and flowers, as well as several seating areas. This zone is designed to be a peaceful spot for local residents to relax and enjoy nature.

Many people have asked about the opening hours. In order to prevent vandalism and ensure safety, the garden will not be open twenty-four hours a day. Instead, the main gates will be unlocked at eight a.m. every morning. During the summer months, they will remain open until eight p.m., but for the autumn and winter seasons, we will close the gates at five p.m. as it gets dark much earlier.

Funding has been a major challenge, but we've been very fortunate. While we did apply for a local council grant, we unfortunately missed the deadline. However, a local business, Green Horizon Landscaping, generously agreed to sponsor our tools and soil. The rest of our funding, which covers the cost of seeds and building materials for the raised beds, was raised through a community bake sale held last month, which brought in over one thousand pounds.

We are also planning our first volunteer day, which will take place next Saturday, the 20th of May. We really need as many hands as possible to help clear the site. You don't need any gardening experience, just a pair of sturdy shoes. We'll provide gloves and all the necessary equipment, as well as complimentary tea, coffee, and biscuits to keep everyone's energy up.

Now, let's look at the specific tasks we need to complete over the next few weeks. Firstly, we need to focus on site preparation. Our main priority next weekend is the removal of rubbish that has accumulated over the years. Please do not try to pull up any weeds yet, as we need to lay down protective sheeting first.

Secondly, we'll begin constructing the raised beds. We've chosen to use timber for these because it's environmentally friendly and looks natural. We will need volunteers who are comfortable using basic hand tools, such as saws and hammers, to help assemble the wooden frames.

Once the frames are up, we'll need to fill them. We've ordered a large delivery of organic compost, which will arrive in bulk bags. We'll need a team of people with wheelbarrows to transport this compost from the main gate to the beds. This is quite physically demanding, so we'll make sure to take regular breaks.

After the beds are prepared, the exciting part begins: planting! We've chosen to start with easy-to-grow vegetables. In particular, we will be planting onions first, as they are very hardy and can be planted early in the season. We will wait until next month to plant the tomatoes and lettuces.

Finally, we are planning to build a small wooden shelter in the corner of the garden. This will serve as a dry place to store our tools, and it will also have a rainwater collection system attached to the roof. We will use this rainwater to irrigate the crops, which is much more sustainable than using tap water.

This is the end of Part 2.

PART 3

You will hear two students, David and Ethan, discussing their university assignment with their tutor, Fiona. You now have some time to look at questions 21 to 30.

Speaker C: Hello, David, Ethan. Come in and take a seat. I wanted to see how you're getting on with your group presentation on renewable energy sources. It's scheduled for next week, isn't it?

Speaker A: Yes, Fiona, it's next Tuesday. We've done quite a lot of research, but we're struggling a bit with how to structure the final part.

Speaker B: That's right. We've got loads of information about solar and wind power, but we aren't sure how much detail to include about newer technologies, like tidal energy.

Speaker C: Well, remember that the presentation is only fifteen minutes long. If you try to cover everything, you'll run out of time. It's much better to focus on the comparison of two main types, and then just briefly mention future trends at the end.

Speaker A: That makes sense. We were thinking of comparing solar power and wind energy because they are the most widely adopted.

Speaker C: That's a sensible approach. What specific aspects of those two are you planning to compare?

Speaker B: We wanted to look at their initial setup costs first. Many people assume solar is always cheaper, but large-scale wind farms can actually be more cost-effective per megawatt.

Speaker C: Good point. What else?

Speaker A: We also wanted to discuss geographical limitations. Obviously, solar needs high solar irradiance, which is why it's so popular in southern regions. But wind turbines need open spaces and consistent wind patterns, which often means offshore locations.

Speaker C: Yes, and offshore wind has its own challenges, especially regarding maintenance. How do you plan to present this visual data?

Speaker B: We've created some bar charts showing the growth of both industries over the last decade. But we were wondering if we should also include a video clip of a wind turbine being installed.

Speaker C: A video can be engaging, but it can also go wrong technically, or eat up too much of your time. I'd stick to the charts. Just make sure the labels on the charts are large enough for the audience to read from the back of the lecture theatre.

Speaker A: Okay, we'll do that. Now, Fiona, we've also been looking at the feedback from our previous presentation on fossil fuels. You mentioned that our delivery was a bit too fast.

Speaker C: Yes, you both tended to rush when you got nervous. It's a very common mistake. Try to build in natural pauses, especially when you transition to a new slide. It gives the audience a moment to digest the information.

Speaker B: Right, we'll practice that. We've scheduled a rehearsal in one of the empty seminar rooms on Thursday.

Speaker C: That's excellent. Now, what about your slides? Have you divided the work of designing them?

Speaker A: Yes, we have. We've split the presentation into five main sections, and we've agreed on who will take responsibility for researching and designing the slides for each one.

Speaker C: Okay, let's go through them. Who is doing the introductory section?

Speaker B: I've already drafted the introduction. It gives a brief history of renewable energy.

Speaker C: Excellent, Ethan. And the section on environmental impact?

Speaker A: I'm handling that one. I want to look at things like land use and how wind turbines affect local bird populations.

Speaker C: Good, David. That's a crucial point. Then there's the section on grid integration. That's quite technical.

Speaker B: Yes, we decided that since I'm studying electrical engineering, I should take charge of that part. I'll explain how battery storage systems help manage the intermittent nature of solar and wind energy.

Speaker C: Perfect. What about the global case studies? You need to show some real-world examples.

Speaker A: We actually found a really interesting case study about Iceland's geothermal energy network. We decided to work on that together, so we'll both be responsible for those slides and present them as a duet.

Speaker C: That can work well if you coordinate it properly. And finally, the conclusion and future outlook?

Speaker B: David is going to wrap things up. He'll summarize our main points and talk about where we think the industry is heading by 2050.

Speaker C: Sounds like a solid plan, boys. I'm looking forward to seeing the final result next Tuesday.

Speaker A: Thanks, Fiona. Your advice has been really helpful.

Speaker B: Yes, thank you. We'll see you on Tuesday!

This is the end of Part 3.

PART 4

You will hear a lecturer called George giving a history presentation on the development of deep-sea diving technology. You now have some time to look at questions 31 to 40.

Speaker A: Good morning, everyone. Today, we're going to explore the fascinating history of deep-sea diving technology. For thousands of years, humans have sought ways to breathe underwater, driven by the desire to harvest resources, salvage sunken treasures, or conduct scientific research.

The earliest recorded attempts at underwater diving didn't involve complex equipment. Ancient divers relied entirely on their own lung capacity. In ancient Greece, divers gathered valuable sea sponges, which were highly prized for bathing and medical purposes. To descend quickly, these divers used a heavy stone, known as a haltere, which they held in their hands to pull them rapidly down to the seabed.

However, the physical limits of breath-holding meant divers could only stay underwater for a couple of minutes. The first major technological breakthrough was the invention of the diving bell in the sixteenth century. This device was essentially a heavy, open-bottomed chamber that was lowered vertically into the water. As it descended, the water pressure trapped a pocket of air inside the top of the bell, allowing divers to breathe.

The primary limitation of early diving bells was the air supply. Once the oxygen inside the bell was consumed, the diver had to return to the surface. In 1690, the English astronomer Edmond Halley made a significant improvement. He designed a system where fresh air was sent down from the surface in weighted wooden barrels. This air was then transferred into the bell via a flexible leather hose, allowing divers to remain submerged for hours at a time.

While diving bells allowed workers to perform salvage operations on the seabed, they did not allow for much mobility. Divers were confined to the immediate area beneath the bell. This led to the development of individual diving suits. In the early nineteenth century, an inventor named John Deane patented a smoke helmet designed for firefighters, which was later adapted for diving. This helmet was placed over the diver's head and supplied with air pumped through a pipe from the surface.

By the 1830s, Augustus Siebe had refined this concept into the closed diving suit, which became the standard for salvage operations for over a century. Siebe's design featured a copper helmet sealed to a waterproof canvas suit. Air was pumped continuously from the surface, and an exhaust valve allowed stale air to escape. This suit gave divers unprecedented freedom of movement, though they were still tethered to the surface by a heavy hose.

The next revolutionary leap occurred in 1943, during the Second World War, with the invention of the Aqua-Lung by Jacques Cousteau and Émile Gagnan. This was the first open-circuit, self-contained underwater breathing apparatus, or SCUBA. The key to its success was the demand regulator. This ingenious valve automatically adjusted the pressure of the air delivered to the diver's lungs, matching the surrounding water pressure. This meant divers no longer needed to *be connected to the surface, allowing them to swim completely freely for the first time.*

With SCUBA technology, marine biology and underwater archaeology flourished. Researchers could now explore coral reefs and shipwrecks in detail. However, human divers are still limited by the physiological effects of deep-water pressure, such as decompression sickness.

To explore the deepest parts of the ocean, scientists had to develop manned submersibles. In 1930, Charles William Beebe and Otis Barton built the Bathysphere. This was a hollow steel sphere that was lowered into the ocean on a steel cable. It was incredibly cramped, but it allowed humans to observe deep-sea life firsthand at depths of over nine hundred meters.

Finally, in 1960, the Swiss physicist Auguste Piccard and his son Jacques designed the Trieste, a deep-diving research submersible known as a bathyscaphe. The Trieste made a historic descent to the bottom of the Mariana Trench, the deepest known point in the Earth's oceans, reaching a depth of nearly eleven thousand meters. This incredible achievement proved that humans could safely travel to the absolute limits of the ocean depths, paving the way for modern robotic exploration.

This is the end of Part 4.